One Snowy Night

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One Snowy Night

by mr darknight hero (hero_hero)

Summary

On his drive home through a snowstorm, Mydei rescues a dog after it's hit by another car.

Notes

last few hours of 2025 and i'm trying to remember how to tag and post. it has been a hot minute

legit just finished this fic today to the surprise of all, especially since i rarely finish fics nowadays AND rarely write something shorter than 20k! i'm also surprised that this is my first phaidei fic since i started writing this fic with zero plans...meanwhile i'm also sitting on a 100k+ phaidei WIP that i've been writing since 3.4 and that i'm hoping to finish and start posting soon!

please enjoy this silly little fic and all its typo glory. hopefully posting this will also bring some snow to my hometown cause how have we only had ONE snowstorm this winter?! pls snow...i want snow... ;-;

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Mydei was not a winter person. In fact, despite living in Okhema, where the winter months often experienced mild to severe snowstorms, he hated the cold, hated the snow, and just hated winter overall. Hated how many layers he wore in order to feel *somewhat* warm, hated how his nose ran, hated the biting winds, hated his dry, cracked lips and hands, hated how the cold made his very bones ache.

But most of all, he hated *driving* in the winter.

Alright, admittedly, he was one of those people who grew up in a warm climate that occasionally saw some rain. AKA, someone who didn't really know how to drive in the snow and panicked at the thought of their commute. He was one of *those* people who drove extremely slow at the mere suggestion of flurries, who was not ashamed to drive with his hazards on the whole way. Cipher liked to tease him about it, calling him a grandma while shaking her head, saying, "So you're one of the idiots causing traffic because of a little dusting. The roads aren't even icy—they're just wet!"

To which Mydei would reply, "You should still be cautious even on wet roads. They could turn into black ice before you know it, and then you're sliding off the road or into someone else. For the safety of yourself and others—"

"Yeah, yeah, drive careful, got it." Cipher waved him off. "You sound like a driving instructor."

At least Castorice was sympathetic, having grown up in Aidonia, whose snowstorms made Okhema look pathetic. Five feet of snow and she would still have school. Mydei was so glad he never lived there.

All this to say, Mydei hated the snow. So when a storm rolled in halfway through his shift, dumping fluffy snow and blanketing the city in white, his heart started pounding while his stomach did flips. But he had no choice. He *had* to drive home. His little coffee shop and bakery, after all, was not suitable for an overnight stay. And Mydei really just wanted to curl up in his comfy bed with his current library book and a cup of tea.

He kept that image of warmth and coziness and safety in his mind as he closed up shop for the night, completed his closing tasks, and put on layer after layer. Long sleeve turtle neck, sweater, warm coat, gloves, hat, scarf. Thank the gods he wore his good, insulated boots today.

It took him fifteen minutes to dig his car out and scrape the ice off. By the time he got in his car, the engine was warm from the time it spent idling, and all the snow melted from Mydei's hair and from the bottom of his boots.

Taking a deep breath, he muttered to himself, "You've got this. Just trust yourself and be careful."

Then he eased out of his parking spot and slowly got onto the road.

To his immense relief, the traffic wasn't as heavy, and the plows had already been out. The roads were certainly icy in spots, but everyone was driving cautiously and Mydei was able to get onto the main road with minimal slipping and sliding. It appeared to him that the snow was just wet and heavy, mostly creating slush instead of ice, especially in the areas where the roads had been treated with sand and salt. It was still precarious, but Mydei found himself breathing a bit easier as he continued on. He even started humming to himself to make up for the lack of music, which he never listened to when there were hazardous road conditions. After all, he had to focus.

Night had fallen, and the flurries drifted through the beams of his headlights, both enchanting and a little distracting. What Mydei wouldn't give to be viewing these drifting snowflakes through a window in his warm townhome. He still had a bit of a ways to go, especially since he had to decrease his speed, but he would be home soon.

He would be home soon.

He was feeling pretty proud of himself for not panicking as much as he usually did, going so far as to find the drive almost *relaxing*, when movement along the side of the road caught his eye.

A moment later, a four-legged shadow darted onto the road ahead of him. Before Mydei could even process whether that was a coyote or a wolf or something else, the car in the lane to his left slammed on its brakes, but not soon enough. The car clipped the animal on its back left hip, causing the poor thing to yelp and tumble onto the road. Out of instinct, Mydei applied his own brakes, right as the animal scrambled up and back the way it came, directly across Mydei's own lane.

The headlights finally illuminated the animal, revealing a bright red collar and wide, terrified eyes.

Mydei instantly turned on his hazards to alert the drivers behind him, then veered off the road and onto the shoulder. The dog scurried in the same direction, limping badly, tail between its legs. It looked so damn scared, and the pained yelp it had released when it was hit still echoed in Mydei's ears.

He knew it was stupid and unsafe, but gods-damn it, he couldn't do *nothing*.

He kicked open his door, the roar of the road and storm blasting him in full force. The dog was panicking again, not sure where to go, and its only two choices were back towards the road where it was hit—three full lanes of faster moving cars—or towards the way it had initially come, which was an on-ramp that was just as busy. Mydei currently had his car at the little junction where the two roads met, in a little triangle of space where cars could pull off in an emergency. But he still wasn't exactly safe, and neither was the dog.

Better make this quick, then.

"Hey!" Mydei shouted. He whistled. "Hey! Come here, boy! Come here!"

The dog perked up at the sound of his voice, then cowered as a truck roared past. It was about to bolt again.

Mydei ran around the front of his car, calling, “Hey! Hey! Good boy! Here, boy! Here, here!”

He waved the dog over as he opened his back door, gesturing frantically for the dog to get in. Mydei was too far away to grab the dog, and he was worried that that would scare it off and back into danger. Mydei really never wanted to see an animal get hit by a car ever again, but especially not a cold, scared, injured pup.

The gods must have been looking down on him, because the dog ran up to him. As soon as it was in reach, Mydei grabbed it by the collar, then half-scooped it up and more or less tossed it into his backseat. Then he slammed the door shut and ran back to the driver’s side.

Only once he shut his own door did he realize how fast his heart was pounding. Mydei gripped the steering wheel to ground himself, then twisted to look back at the dog in the backseat.

“Are you okay, buddy? Are you hurt?” he asked, only to cringe when he remembered the dog’s pronounced limp. “Don’t worry, you’re a good boy, and you’re safe now. Okay? I’m gonna get you home.”

The dog—a big, white, fluffy thing, its fur currently gray and muddy from the snow—was curled up and violently trembling on the seat. But at the sound of Mydei’s voice, its ears lowered and its tail thumped against the seat. Mydei’s heart ached.

He turned his attention back to the road, still pulled off on the side with his hazards on. Cars zoomed past, splashing his car with dirty slush. He realized in that moment that he had no idea what to do. The stupidity and recklessness of the situation dawned on him. He could have been hit. He could have caused another accident. The dog could have bitten him out of fear. The dog *still* could bite him. And then if he didn’t die from that, he’d still have to get a rabies shot, just to be safe—

Mydei pressed the heels of his palms into his eyes and took a deep breath. When he dropped his hands, he turned to look at the dog again.

Thump-thump-thump, went the dog’s tail.

Mydei smiled. “Let’s get you to a vet first, okay?” An idea popped into his head. “And I know just the place. Don’t worry, buddy, we’ll get you taken care of.”

With that in mind, he took another deep breath, put on his signal, and merged back onto the road.

*

Twilight Courtyard Animal Clinic was a quaint, stand-alone building, which Mydei passed every day on his way to work. It was actually only about a couple of minutes from his townhouse. Now, in the winter storm, its wide front windows allowed a warm light to spill out on the fresh snow, a beacon for those whose animals needed warmth, safety, and care.

Mydei was immensely relieved that it was still open despite being past 5pm. He wasn't sure of the clinic's hours until now, where the bright red neon lights next to the main sign said: *24/7 ER CARE*.

He pulled into a parking spot as close to the front door as possible, then got out and went around to the rear passenger door. The dog thumped its tail against the seat once more. Mydei smiled.

"Alright, buddy, let's get you out." Mydei carefully scooped the dog up and lifted him out of the car. The dog was able to walk on three legs, heavily favoring its back left leg. Mydei debated just carrying the dog all the way in, but he wasn't sure if that would cause the dog any more harm or pain. Besides, Mydei wasn't even sure what other injuries this poor dog had.

He wished he had a leash, though. Mydei had no choice but to hunch over and hold onto the dog's collar and lead him inside that way.

The lobby was wonderfully warm and empty as Mydei and the dog entered. A bell jingled above the door, and a young woman in scrubs with her pastel hair in pigtails came out from a back hallway to stand behind the front desk.

"Hello there!" she said brightly. "What brings you in today?"

"Hello," Mydei said, gently tugging the dog forward. "Um, this actually isn't my dog, but I saw him get hit by a car on my way home, so—"

"Oh my goodness!" The vet tech rushed over and crouched down beside the dog. "Poor thing!"

"Yeah, the car in front of me clipped his back left hip, and he took a tumble but then got up and ran in front of my car," Mydei said. "I pulled over and managed to get him safely into my car. And now here we are."

As he spoke, the vet tech, whose name tag read *Hyacine*, carefully ran her hands along the dog's body, feeling for injuries and pain. The dog turned to lick her hands, inching away from her when she tried to feel its hips.

"You did the right thing," Hyacine told Mydei. "You saved this precious pup's life!"

"I just couldn't leave him there." Mydei crouched down too and pet the dog's fluffy head. The dog licked his hands, tongue lolling as its mouth stretched into a happy smile. "Will he be okay?"

“Oh, I’m sure he will be, but he’ll definitely need emergency surgery,” Hyacine said. “We’ll get him back and do a proper examination first.”

She reached for the dog’s collar and fished the tag out of the dog’s thick, fluffy fur. “Snowy,” she read, and the dog wagged his tail. Hyacine smiled. “Aw, so sweet! As expected from a samoyed!”

“Oh, that’s what he is,” Mydei said. “I’m not really a dog person, so…”

“Yep, lovely dogs! They love the snow and cold, since they were bred to be sled dogs. I’ll bet Snowy here escaped his backyard to go play in the snow!” Hyacine smiled and stood. “Come on, Snowy, let’s get you treats and back to a room for some x-rays!”

“Do you need me to do anything?” Mydei stood as well. “Is there a number on his collar? I could call his owner.”

“No need, we’ll call,” Hyacine said. “We’ll need the owner’s consent before we do any kind of operation, anyways. But you’re welcome to wait until they arrive!”

Mydei nodded. “I think I will. I want to make sure he’ll be okay.”

After Hyacine coaxed Snowy back into the exam room, Mydei found a seat by the front windows, with nothing left to do but wait. He looked out at the parking lot, where even in the few minutes he had been here, his car had been covered in a thin layer of snow. Mydei sighed. The snow didn’t look like it would be letting up anytime soon. At least Mydei didn’t live too far.

He wondered what would happen to Snowy. Would they keep him overnight? They had to, didn’t they? Especially if they were going to do surgery? *Would* they have to do surgery? What did you even do if your dog broke their hip and maybe their ribs and possibly even a leg? What about internal injuries, like bleeding and such? When was it more humane to euthanize instead of let the dog suffer?

Snowy seemed fine, though. In desperate need of a bath, sure, but surprisingly fine from being hit by a car, despite the limp. But who knew what other injuries the dog had?

Mydei sighed and played with his necklace. He had no doubt that the owner—if they showed—would be devastated regardless. But at least their dog was found and somewhat safe, right? Better than Snowy still fearfully running through the streets, cold and injured and alone. There was some comfort in that, right?

Mydei sat and waited, completely alone in the waiting room. No other patients came in. The snow continued to fall.

Then—headlights in the parking lot. A car pulled up in front of the clinic, and someone jumped out of the backseat. The car drove off as that person wrenched open the front door and dashed inside.

“Uh—hello? Hello? Anyone there?” The person—a man around Mydei’s age—rushed up to the empty front desk and rang the little bell on the counter. He sounded like he was out of breath and possibly on the verge of tears, and honestly, Mydei couldn’t blame him.

But when Hyacine didn’t appear, Mydei stood and approached the man, clearing his throat.

“Um, I think they’re all busy at the moment, but someone should be out soon, hopefully,” he said. “They just took Snowy back to do some x-rays.”

The man turned to look at Mydei, eyes wide. Mydei blinked back, processing the fact that they were seeing eye to eye. Mydei wasn’t used to meeting people who were as tall as him. It was both unnerving and refreshing.

He briefly took in the rest of the man’s appearance. Messy white hair and stunning blue eyes with flecks of gold, slightly reddened at the edges. And then the rest of him—a bright yellow puffer jacket over an old, purple sweatshirt that said THE GROVE on it in faded letters, and —

Mydei blinked. What the hell were those *pants*?

“Do your pants have…*dromases* on them?” The words were out of Mydei’s mouth before he could stop them.

“Wha—? Oh.” The man looked down and groaned. “Yeah. I, um, threw on whatever I had before leaving my apartment to look for Snowy.”

Right. This man had lost his dog and was now at the vet for said dog, with probably no details about what had transpired. Mydei felt like an idiot and a jerk.

“My apologies,” Mydei said, tearing his eyes away from the dromas pants. He looked back up, met the man’s blue eyes, and smiled politely. “I’m Mydei. I found Snowy and brought him here. I’m not sure what else they told you.”

The man’s eyes went wide again. “You—you found Snowy? Where was he?”

Mydei winced. “Um…” Gods, did *he* have to be the one to deliver the bad news?

“Oh, wait, you must have found him on the side of the road.” The man swallowed, lip starting to tremble. “They—they said he—he got hit by a car—?” His voice broke.

Mydei nodded. “I…I saw it happen. But the car tried to brake and wasn’t going that fast because of the snow. Snowy jumped right back up and ran back the way he came. That was how I was able to pull over and coax him into my car.”

The man sniffed and quickly rubbed at his eyes. “Is he—is he going to be okay? Oh my gods, he must have been so scared—and in so much pain, and he probably had no idea what was happening and just—” His voice broke again.

Thankfully, before Mydei could fail even more spectacularly at delivering the news and comforting this emotional owner, Hyacine appeared behind the desk.

“Hi!” she said with a smile. “Are you Phainon? Snowy’s owner?”

The man—Phainon—turned and managed to smile back. “Yeah—that’s me. Is Snowy okay? Is he hurt badly?”

“We just did some x-rays, and it shows that he broke his hip and fractured his back leg,” Hyacine said. “He needs surgery, so we’re preparing to do that now. But I think he’ll pull through just fine! We’ll need to keep him overnight to monitor him. Is that alright with you?”

“Yeah, yeah, of course! Do whatever you need to do. Just…help him. Please.”

“We will certainly do everything we can.” Hyacine rummaged through the desk before pulling out a clipboard and pen. “I’ll just need you to sign a few documents…”

Mydei waited awkwardly to the side as Hyacine guided Phainon through the paperwork. He wasn’t sure if he should stay or not. Something was telling him that he needed to stay, needed to talk to Phainon or even Hyacine again. It would be almost rude if he tried to leave now. But it still felt uncomfortable, since Snowy wasn’t his dog and he didn’t know a thing about Phainon.

He waited and waited, and soon Hyacine was smiling and turning back to her computer to finish some things before going back to the exam room again. Phainon let out a breath and ran a shaky hand through his messy, pale hair.

His hair looks soft, Mydei thought to himself, then mentally smacked himself.

“I should, uh,” Phainon sounded dazed, “I should call Cyrene. Yeah, I should let her know he’s safe…”

He pulled out his phone, biting his chapped lips as he found the contact and pressed call. To Mydei’s surprise, he put the call on speaker. It rang only a few times before a bright, feminine voice answered.

“Phainon?”

“Hey, I have an update.” Phainon let out another breath. “Someone found him. I’m—I’m at the vet right now.”

“Oh—is Snowy okay?”

“I—I think so. But he has to have surgery and stay overnight because he—” Phainon swallowed thickly, lower lip trembling. “He got hit by a car and—” His voice broke and he burst into tears.

Mydei shifted uncomfortably, now seriously unsure of what to do as this stranger bawled in the middle of the waiting room. The girl on the other end—Cyrene—spoke softly and comfortingly as she tried to console Phainon, who rubbed harshly at his own face and nodded as he listened and tried to stop crying. Mydei wished he knew what to do, but Cyrene sounded like she was pretty good at comforting Phainon. Mydei almost took mental notes.

The call finally ended with Cyrene making Phainon promise to go home, get some sleep, and try not to worry. Phainon nodded and mumbled his promise before saying, “I love you,” and hanging up after Cyrene said it back.

The waiting room fell into another uncomfortable silence, broken only by Phainon sighing and covering his face with his hands. Mydei shifted his weight again, then said, “Your girlfriend?”

“What?” Phainon dropped his hands to blink at him. When Mydei nodded at Phainon’s phone, Phainon glanced at it and realized what Mydei was asking. “Oh! Oh, no, no, my sister.”

“Oh,” Mydei said, feeling awkward.

“Yeah. She, uh—” Phainon sniffed. “She lives in Janusopolis. Going to school there.”

“I see.”

“Sorry you had to see me fall apart there.” Phainon fidgeted with his phone. “I, uh, I, like, never cry but—”

“Don’t apologize,” Mydei hurried to say. “It’s fine. I get it. I’d be a mess too if I were you.”

Phainon managed a watery smile. “Do you have dogs too?”

“Er—no. More of a cat person. But I don’t have any pets currently.”

“Oh. Gotcha.”

Another awkward silence. An analog clock ticked in the corner.

“Thank you again for saving Snowy and bringing him here,” Phainon said. “I don’t think I thanked you in the first place, actually. But seriously, thank you.”

“Of course,” Mydei said. “I’m sorry he was hit. I would give anything to go back in time and stop that from happening.”

“No, no, it wasn’t your fault!” Phainon said. “If anything, it’s mine. I should have been keeping an eye on him…” He winced as his eyes welled with tears. “I’m the worst dog owner ever.”

“What happened, if you don’t mind me asking?”

“Well, I live in an apartment, and I know that’s like the worst setup for a dog like Snowy, but I’ve had him since I was a kid, and he’s always been *my dog*, not the *family’s* dog, and so when I moved to Okhema I couldn’t just leave him behind in Aedes Elysiae, so I brought him with me, but I can tell he’s not nearly as happy and I get it because he had a yard back home but here he has a balcony and has to wait for me to take him outside and I’m really busy with work and school, so I don’t get him on walks that often or take him out in the snow and he *loves* the snow, so today I took him out but when we went to the dog park by my apartment,

he saw something and bolted and there was a gap in the fence or something and I was checking something on my phone but when I looked up, I couldn't see Snowy *anywhere* and he wouldn't come when I called and I know he's a samoyed so he blends in with the snow and I panicked because I *knew* he'd get hurt or killed and it would all be my fault because I'm an idiot who couldn't look away from his stupid phone for five minutes to play with his dog and I just—" Phainon sucked in a breath and dropped his face into his hands again. "I'm the worst person alive!"

And then he started crying again.

Mydei blinked at him, caught off-guard and scrambling to think of something to say. He thought of how Cyrene had consoled Phainon, but that wouldn't sound right coming from Mydei, so he had to think of something else.

"Don't blame yourself, it was an accident," Mydei said. "You couldn't have known that there was a gap in the fence. Besides, you went out in a snowstorm to play with your dog, didn't you? That doesn't sound like a bad owner to me. Quite the opposite, actually. I can't think of many people who would want to do that."

Phainon looked up at him, blinking. His blue eyes were even more alluring through tears. Mydei found it hard to look away. How could someone look so beautiful even when they were ugly sobbing?

Not the time, Mydei mentally scolded himself.

"Snowy will be okay," Mydei said. "And so will you. He's alive, and he's getting the care he needs, and soon you'll both be back home, safe and sound."

Phainon nodded, lip still wobbling. "Thank you," he said. "And…thank you for listening to me. You really didn't need to know all of that. Sorry for talking your ear off and bawling. You probably just want to get home, and here you are, stuck listening to my stupid sob story…"

"I don't mind." Mydei smiled. "I wanted to stay and make sure you and Snowy were okay anyways."

Phainon blushed at that. "I seriously owe you one. Um, could I pay you back? Like, name your price. I'll literally do anything. I owe you my life!"

Mydei laughed. "No need, seriously. I'm just glad Snowy is okay. That's enough for me."

Phainon shook his head. "No, no, I want to pay you back. I have to show my gratitude *somehow*."

"You already have. You thanked me profusely. Several times, might I add."

Phainon huffed. "Yeah, but that's not enough! Can I like…treat you to dinner or something?"

Like a date? Mydei almost said, but caught himself. "No need," he said.

Phainon groaned. “Mydeiiiiiiiii, come on, work with me here!”

Mydei ignored the way his heart fluttered at the sound of his name in Phainon’s voice. “You have bigger things to worry about than paying me back.”

Phainon whimpered at that, once again making Mydei’s heart go crazy while his stomach did flips. “True, but still…”

“How about this? I’ll give you my number, and you can text me updates on Snowy and let me know if you need my help taking care of him. Deal?”

“Wha—how is that me paying you back if I’m just bothering you further?!” Yet Phainon was blushing even more.

Mydei shrugged. “I want to make sure Snowy is okay. But I’m a stranger and have no right to know the details of his health and well-being or of your life. But it doesn’t hurt to ask.”

“Well, the simple solution then is to make you not a stranger anymore,” Phainon said.

“Sure. So we can start by you texting me updates.”

Phainon smiled. “Alright. I guess that works for now. But I still want to pay you back, okay? Even if you need me to like pay for your groceries or buy you something. Just let me know.”

Mydei smirked. “I’m not going to get out of this debt, am I?”

“Not until you cash it in!”

“That’s typically how debts work.”

Phainon huffed, which made Mydei laugh.

“Alright, I don’t think we should stay here for much longer,” Mydei said. “There’s nothing more we can do, so might as well head home and come back in the morning.”

“Yeah, snow’s really coming down now, too.” Phainon looked outside and sighed. “Guess I should call an Uber now. Might take them a while.” He pulled out his phone.

“Do you live far?”

“Not too bad. Like fifteen minutes or so. You?”

“I’m nearby. Need a ride?”

“What?” Phainon blinked at him. “No, no, that’s okay, you should head home! Don’t worry about me.”

“Again, I don’t mind,” Mydei said. “As long as you don’t mind me driving like a grandma.”

Phainon snorted. “That’s just being safe in this weather.”

Mydei smiled and pulled out his keys. “Exactly. Come on, I’ll drive you home.”

“My debt is getting bigger and bigger,” Phainon said. “Are you an angel? Or a serial killer?”

“Would a serial killer save a dog from the side of the road?”

“Point taken. Angel it is, then.” Phainon smiled.

Mydei had to look away from that adorable smile before he blushed too much and embarrassed himself. “Nah. This is just common decency. My mother raised me well.”

“Well, tell your mother I love her,” Phainon said as they walked to the door. “And that she’s amazing.”

Mydei snorted as he held the door open for him. “My mother is not easily charmed or flattered, but I’ll be sure to pass on the message.”

“Aw, c’mon, everyone’s mother loves me!” Phainon shivered against the cold. “I think I could totally charm her.”

“Now I almost want to see you try.”

“Challenge accepted, Mydei!”

Mydei huffed, smiling as he hid his face in his scarf.

*

“So…what do you do for a living, Mydei? Or are you in school as well?”

Mydei squinted at the road, where the snow had finally let up to just a few charming flurries. “I own a bakery and cafe.”

“Whoa, what?” Phainon twisted in the passenger seat to look at him. “For real? That’s awesome!”

“Mm-hmm. It’s been an old dream of mine. And it’s actually doing quite well. So that’s nice.”

“I’ll have to come by sometime,” Phainon said. “What’s the name of your bakery?”

“The Pink Pomegranate.”

Phainon stared. “Shut up.”

“What?” Mydei glanced at him in surprise, but Phainon was staring in wonder.

“That’s right by my job! I pass by it all the time! I’ve been meaning to pop in since my friend Castorice works there now, but I haven’t had the time.”

“You’re friends with Castorice?” Mydei glanced at him again. “I’m friends with her and Cipher.”

“That’s crazy!” Phainon grinned. “We have mutual friends and could have crossed paths before…small world, huh?”

“Who knows—maybe we *have* walked right past each other before.”

Phainon shook his head. “Nuh-uh, I would have remembered you if we had. And probably would have thought of you for the rest of my life, wondering what could have been...”

Mydei blushed a little at that and glanced at him. To his delight, Phainon was also bright red.

“Er—that kinda came out wrong,” Phainon said. “I mean that I couldn’t have forgotten you even if I tried and probably would have beat myself up for not stopping to talk to you. Wait, that’s not any better—”

Mydei laughed. “I get what you’re trying to say, don’t worry. To be fair, I wouldn’t have forgotten those dromas-patterned pants so easily either.”

Phainon groaned and covered his face with his hands. “Oh, gods, I’m already mortified enough that I met you when you look like *that* and I’m literally wearing my pajamas. No need to rub it in!!”

“I’m just teasing,” Mydei said. “They’re cute. They look very comfy. But also…what do you mean by me looking ‘like that’?”

“You’re really just trying to make me die of embarrassment tonight, huh?” Phainon sighed. “Well, I guess I can’t embarrass myself more than I already have. So, I mean you look like you stepped right off the runway for some fashion designer’s winter collection. Or right out of an L.L. Bean magazine ad. Or even a Hallmark Christmas movie where you’re the hot, small-town lumberjack who teaches the career lady the meaning of the holidays. Actually, while we’re at it, are you interested in modeling? My friend and mentor is a fashion designer and would probably have a field day with someone like you.”

There was a lot to process in that deluge of words, but all Mydei could say was, “Someone like me?”

Phainon sighed again. “Are you really going to make me say it?”

“Say *what*?”

“Ugh, just playing dumb in order for me to fall for it, and y’know what, it’s working.” Phainon sighed yet a third time and said, “Someone drop-dead gorgeous like you, who could probably pull a Marylin Monroe and make a potato sack look good on them. Someone who looks all buff and intimidating with their RBF but actually spends their free-time reading to

children and rescuing injured dogs from the side of the road. Someone who somehow manages to make face tattoos look elegant. See what I mean? Fashion designer's *dream*."

Mydei snorted to himself and smiled. "Well…I do volunteer at the library every Saturday to read to kids and run some events, so you weren't far off from that one. And they're not just face tattoos—I actually have them all over my body. Same design, though."

Phainon was silent, which made Mydei look at him again. Phainon was gaping at him.

"What?" Mydei said.

"How are you *real*?" Phainon said. "Like, seriously. You're just the whole package, aren't you?"

Mydei lifted one shoulder in a shrug. "I don't do any of that for attention. It's just what I enjoy."

"Gorgeous, kind, *and* humble," Phainon mumbled while crossing his arms. "Probably rich, too?"

Mydei pressed his lips together.

"Shut up." Phainon was back to gaping at him. "You're kidding."

"My family is…comfortable," Mydei decided to say.

"Oh, sure, that's what people say when they don't want others to know that their dad owns a sports team or something."

Again, Mydei stayed silent.

Phainon looked at him sharply. "No way."

Mydei cleared his throat.

"How the fuck—what team?!"

"The, um, Castrum Kremnos Warriors."

"The fucking Castrum Kremnos Warriors?!" Phainon's voice went shrill. "They're like the second-best hockey team in the world!"

"Second-best?" Mydei snorted. "They *are* the best."

"Nope, Okhema's Chrysos Heirs are better." Phainon crossed his arms. "Look up the stats. Fight me on it. Go on."

Mydei snorted. "No need, I'm actually not much of a hockey fan. Or any sports fan."

"Bullshit, how could you not be when your dad fucking owns a team? You probably grew up learning the business and living and breathing hockey!"

“I did. But I hated it, so I chose to leave. Hence the bakery.”

“Do you still play at all?”

“Nope.”

“Aw. I was wondering if you’d want to play with me. We have a team down at the local ice rink, if you’re ever interested.”

Mydei shook his head. “I’ll pass. I hate the cold and the ice.”

“Mm, fair.”

Mydei pulled up in front of Phainon’s apartment building. After putting the car in park, he looked at Phainon.

“Well, thanks again for the ride,” Phainon said as he unbuckled. “And for saving my dog. And for putting up with me. I still owe you.”

Mydei snorted. “All the least I could do.”

“Not true,” Phainon said. “You could have driven away. You could have left the moment you dropped Snowy off. You could have let me get home on my own. But you didn’t. You stayed.”

“And I’m glad I did.” Mydei smiled at him.

Phainon blushed and fumbled for the door handle. “Well, I, uh, should try to go get some sleep. Drive safely, okay? I’ll keep you updated on Snowy whenever I hear anything.”

Mydei nodded. “Sounds good. Sleep well, Phainon.”

Phainon practically fell out of the car. But before he shut the door, he leaned down and asked through the doorway, “Are you real?”

Mydei snorted again. “I’m real.”

“You seem way too good to be true. Just—wow. Anyways. Goodnight, Mydei! See you tomorrow!”

“See you tomorrow, Phainon.”

Mydei smiled to himself as he watched Phainon enter his apartment building. He was still smiling to himself as he got back onto the road and began the final trek home. And even when he finally, *finally* stepped into his warm and cozy townhome and brushed the snow off his clothes and headed into the kitchen to make a cup of herbal tea, he still had a smile on his face and a warmth in his chest that made the cold a little easier to bear.

*

Mydei was in the middle of his morning workout the following day when he got a text from Phainon.

Phainon:

Hey! Snowy is ready to come home if you want to meet me at the vet to see him???

Mydei smiled and texted back immediately.

Mydei:

Sure. Need a ride?

Phainon:

That would be really nice…

Mydei:

Sure thing. Be there in 30.

The roads were mostly plowed but still icy in some places as Mydei drove to Phainon's apartment. But the storm had passed and the sun was shining; despite the cold, it was a beautiful day.

Phainon was waiting outside his building when Mydei pulled up. He beamed and gave a little wave before dashing down the front steps and up to the passenger door. Mydei smiled and couldn't help noticing that Phainon had dressed a bit nicer today—dark grey trousers, black boots, crisp blue button-up with the collar folded over the hem of a dark blue sweater, all tied together with a white puffer jacket that was unzipped down the front. The colors suited him. They also reminded Mydei of this beautiful winter day (and a bit of Snowy, which Mydei found amusing).

"Hi!" Phainon said as he opened the door. "Still real, I see! Still not a figment of my imagination!"

“Still real,” Mydei confirmed. “Hurry up and get in before people start to wonder why you’re talking to thin air.”

“Ha, ha, very funny.” Phainon did, in fact, get in.

As they got back on the road, Mydei glanced at him. “Get any sleep?”

“Surprisingly, yes,” Phainon said. “I basically went home and was so exhausted that I passed out on my bed. Barely remembered to take my shoes off!”

“Well, you *were* already in your cozy dromas pajamas, so—”

Phainon sighed. “You’re never gonna let me live that down, are you? What do *you* sleep in, Mr. Future CEO? Custom silk pajamas with your name embroidered in gold over the breast pocket?”

Mydei *did* have a pair of pajamas close to that description, but he was not about to admit that to Phainon of all people. Instead, he said, “Usually I just sleep in the nude.”

“Wha—” Phainon’s face turned bright red as he essentially short-circuited. Spluttering, he said, “I—I didn’t need to know that, Mydei!”

Mydei shrugged. “You asked.”

“Ugh.” Phainon dropped his face into his hands.

Mydei was only partially kidding; he did sometimes sleep wearing nothing at all, but that was usually only in the summer, not when it was fucking freezing out.

Changing the subject, he asked, “Excited to see Snowy?”

“Very! My apartment was so lonely last night.” Phainon sighed. “I hope he did okay overnight…he must have been so scared…”

“He probably just slept, since the drugs they give them are pretty powerful,” Mydei said. “I’m sure he’ll be very happy to see you, though.”

Phainon smiled at that.

They reached the clinic in no time. Phainon practically tripped over himself to get the car door open, and then almost ate shit on some lingering black ice. By the time Mydei opened his mouth to warn him to be careful, Phainon had already recovered and was rushing towards the front doors. Mydei snorted and followed.

The clinic was busier that morning, full of a couple of people and their pets in the waiting room. Hyacine with her bouncy, colorful pigtails was behind the counter, getting another patient and their golden retriever checked in. Phainon and Mydei waited in line, with Phainon tapping his foot and chewing on his lip.

Mydei glanced at the other people and their pets and smiled. One day, he'd get a pet of his own. An orange cat, perhaps. He had always wanted one of those. At the moment, there was one in a cat carrier, tail lashing as its owner read a magazine in the chair next to it. The cat glared at Mydei through the mesh of its carrier, as if to say, *Free me from my prison, human. Spare me this indignity.* Mydei snorted.

Then it was Phainon's turn, and Hyacine beamed at them as they stepped up to the counter.

"Mr. Phainon!" she greeted brightly. "So good to see you again! Now, before you see Snowy, I'll need you to sign some more papers and pay his bill. And don't worry—Snowy did great! The surgery went very smoothly! He'll be a little tired for the next few days as the pain meds wear off, but here's a list of all the medications he'll have to take, as well as instructions for care and recovery."

Mydei stepped up beside Phainon, shoulders brushing, as he glanced at the discharge papers.

"You'll have to schedule a follow-up visit as well as a visit to a physical therapist," Hyacine continued. "The physical therapist is optional but highly recommended. At least visit once so you can learn how to help Snowy recover full mobility in a safe and healthy manner!"

"Thank you so much," Phainon said. "Seriously, you have no idea how happy and grateful I am that you were able to help him and that he'll be as good as new soon!"

"Well, it will take a bit before he's feeling himself again, but he's strong and healthy, so I have no doubt he'll get there!" Hyacine printed another page and retrieved it from the printer. "Now, here is the amount you owe today. We did have to charge a bit more for the additional hardware that went into his hip, but the total should be right there at the bottom…"

Phainon took one look at the receipt and froze, all color draining from his face. Mydei glanced at him before glancing at the invoice; Phainon made no effort to hide it from him.

"That's—" Phainon swallowed before trying again, "That's a lot more than I was expecting. Um. Are there, like, payment plan options? I just—wow. I really can't afford to pay the full amount up front today."

Hyacine's expression was full of sympathy. "We do offer payment plans, but they charge interest as part of the clinic's policy, and you'd end up paying even more in the long run. It's recommended that you pay the full amount up front."

"But…what if I can't? Will you just…take my dog away from me?"

"No, no, of course not—Snowy will come home with you today for sure, but you could be hit with a massive late fee if you fail to pay—"

Mydei tossed his credit card onto the counter. "We'll pay the full amount up front today. Please use this card."

"What?" Phainon gaped at him. "But, Mydei! That's way too much, and—"

“And what?” Mydei raised his eyebrows at him, but his tone was gentle. “I’m doing this willingly without any expectation of you owing me. Besides, we both know I can certainly afford it.”

“But he’s not even your dog and you’ve already done so much! At least let me pay for some of it and then I’ll pay the rest when I get paid next. Or, I can call Cyrene or my parents and get you the full amount—”

“Nope, not a chance.”

Phainon groaned, but Hyacine giggled as she ran the credit card. She printed out another copy of the invoice and pushed it and a pen towards Mydei. “If you’ll just sign there, sir. I’ll go get Snowy in one moment!”

As Hyacine went back to get Snowy, and Mydei calmly tucked his credit card back into his wallet, Phainon pouted at him. Mydei couldn’t help snorting.

“What?” Mydei asked.

“I’m scheming of ways to pay you back,” Phainon said.

“Does that scheme involve giving me puppy eyes?”

“Depends—is it working? My momma always said my puppy-dog eyes could get me anything.”

Mydei huffed, still smirking. “Well, almost anything. You’re not paying me back.”

“Oh come on!” Phainon almost stomped his foot. “Can I please take you out for dinner or something? Or—or! What about this? I come eat at your bakery every day for at least a year! And I’ll tell everyone I know about it! I’ll do free promotion wherever I go! I’ll even design a t-shirt and wear it everywhere!”

Mydei snorted, heart swelling with warmth as he crossed his arms. “Well, I wouldn’t object to you stopping by every now and then. And promotion is always appreciated. But not required.”

Phainon opened his mouth to reply, but then the door to the back of the clinic opened, and Snowy appeared, wearing a plastic cone. At the sight of Phainon, he scrambled forward, practically dragging poor Hyacine as his nails scraped across the tile floors.

“Careful, careful!” Hyacine warned. “You’re still recovering!”

Phainon laughed, eyes filling with tears as he crouched down and held his arms open wide. Snowy dove towards him, smacking him with the cone on accident. Somehow, Snowy still managed to cover Phainon’s face in slobbery kisses. Phainon just laughed some more and threw his arms around his dog, fingers curling into the fluffy, white fur.

“Good boy,” Phainon whispered. “Good boy, Snowy.”

Mydei smiled and looked Snowy over. His entire left hip and leg had been shaved, and a long incision traveled down the length of it, disappearing under a wrap around Snowy's leg. He still walked stiffly and with a limp, but it was clear that he was still better than when he came in.

Phainon sniffed, wiped the slobber and tears off his face, and looked up at Hyacine, who still held Snowy's leash. "So, you were saying about him still being groggy from the drugs…?"

Hyacine laughed, and even Mydei huffed quietly. Snowy took the opportunity to lick Phainon's face again, smacking Phainon with the edge of the cone once more. Phainon just laughed and scratched behind Snowy's ears.

Mydei worried that it would be a hassle getting Snowy into the car, but Snowy leapt into the backseat with ease, like he hadn't just come out of surgery for a broken hip and leg. Phainon wanted to sit in the back, but a bit of convincing had him sitting in the front seat instead. That way, Snowy could have the whole backseat to himself, and he promptly lied down, his adrenaline and excitement already fading.

"He looks tired now," Mydei remarked as they buckled in.

"Yeah. I hope he's not in any pain." Phainon twisted in his seat to look at Snowy, brow furrowed. *Thump-thump-thump*, went Snowy's tail against the seat. Phainon smiled. "Ready to go home, bud?"

Thump-thump-thump! Snowy's pink tongue lolled as his mouth stretched into a big, happy, samoyed smile.

Phainon laughed. "I bet you are! Hyacine said I should put an old t-shirt on you to cover the incision and keep you from licking. But the cone will have to stay on for a little while. I know that sucks. Sorry, bud. But you'll feel better and heal in no time!"

He stayed twisted like that the whole drive, chatting away to his dog. Mydei considered telling Phainon to sit forward for safety reasons but then thought better of it. He was driving like a grandma, anyways. And it wasn't far. Mydei could let this one slide.

Despite his slow driving, they reached Phainon's apartment building faster than Mydei would have liked. Soon Phainon was unbuckling and getting out of the car. By the time Mydei stepped out of his own side, Phainon was already opening the rear passenger door for Snowy and helping him out of the car.

Phainon looked up and smiled at Mydei, who walked around the front to stand before him. "I can't thank you enough for everything," Phainon said. "For saving him, for the car rides, for paying—not to mention for listening to me and putting up with me. Just…thank you, seriously."

"Would do it all again in a heartbeat." Mydei smiled. "Do you need help walking him up?"

"Oh, no, no, we're fine. There's an elevator."

“Okay.”

A beat of awkward silence passed, where Mydei realized that this might be the last time he saw Phainon or Snowy. Even though they were still practically strangers, Mydei’s heart pounded with panic at the thought of never seeing Phainon again. Or at least not for a long time, since there was a chance that they might meet again because of their mutual friends…

“Do you—” Mydei started to say at the same time Phainon said, “Would you—”

They both stopped, blinking at each other, then laughed.

“Go ahead,” Mydei said.

“No, no, you first,” Phainon said.

Realizing that they could just go back and forth like this, Mydei said, “Do you still want to go to dinner?”

Phainon blinked, eyes going wide.

“Er—not tonight,” Mydei said quickly. “I know you have a lot on your plate and can’t leave Snowy that soon, but—”

“Yes!” Phainon blurted. “I mean, yeah, not tonight, but yes, I’d really love to go to dinner with you. My treat, remember?”

Mydei snorted. “Unless I catch the bill first.”

“You’d better not! I have like a million dinners to treat you to!”

“Oh?” Mydei arched an eyebrow. “Moving fast, aren’t you?”

Phainon turned red. “I mean—to pay you back. I’d need to take you to like a million dinners.”

“And here I was hoping you’d take me just because you enjoyed my company.”

“Er—wait, I do! I do! But I also—oh gods.” Phainon covered his face with his free hand, groaning.

Mydei laughed. “I’m just teasing. A million dinners with you sounds like an enjoyable challenge. I accept. Though, if I still manage to catch the bill before you at each of those dinners, does that mean you add another dinner to the challenge?”

“I—” Phainon stared at him, wide-eyed. He must have short-circuited again.

Mydei snorted. “No need to rush. We’ll start with one. Are you free next Thursday? You can choose the place. I’ll pick you up.”

“Next Thursday is so far away, though,” Phainon whined. “But…if that’s what works for you, it works for me, too.”

“Great. See you then. Don’t forget to text me updates about Snowy, though, okay?” Mydei then crouched down to pet Snowy. Snowy licked his hand and panted happily as Mydei scratched behind an ear. “Good boy. Glad you’re safe and sound and home with your dad. No running off, now, okay?”

“Trust me, I’m gonna write so many complaints about the upkeep of that stupid dog park!” Phainon huffed. “They don’t empty the trash or refill the poop bags *nearly* as often as they should! And they should enforce picking up after your dog! Just the other day I had to clean off a pair of my—” He stopped and flushed. “Er—never mind. You don’t need to know any of that. Um. Drive safe, okay? Text me if you need anything.”

“You too,” Mydei said, standing. He met Phainon’s gaze and smiled. “I expect pictures of Snowy on a daily basis.”

Phainon smiled. “Deal.”

They stood and gazed at each other for a few moments, neither wanting to be the one to look away first. Phainon’s eyes were so beautiful. Mydei was certain he had never seen such lovely eyes before. He wanted to keep staring.

He ended up being the one to look away first, but only to glance down at Phainon’s outfit. “Um, before I go, I also wanted to say—nice outfit. Although I miss the dromas pants, this all looks very nice on you.”

To his delight, Phainon blushed. “Thank you. Um. Would you believe me if I said I was a design student? With a cross-discipline in fashion design?”

“Well, artists are always a bit…eccentric, aren’t they?” Mydei smiled. “You’re just trying new things before they become trends.”

Phainon snorted. “Yeah, well, you’re talking to the guy who only works in black and white or in very limited palettes because his color theory sucks, so…”

Mydei shrugged. “So what? That could be your signature style. Besides, isn’t monochrome a challenge in of itself? You have to play with shapes and silhouettes and textures to make it interesting.”

Phainon’s eyes lit up, but then he glanced down at Snowy. “Gah, now I just want to talk to you for hours! Why are you so easy to talk to? Ugh, but I should really get Snowy inside. He’s probably exhausted. And hungry. But we *will* continue this conversation later, okay? We’ll pick it up next Thursday!”

“Right, right, sorry, didn’t mean to keep you for so long,” Mydei said, taking a step towards his car and fidgeting with his keys. “But I look forward to it. See you next Thursday, Phainon.”

Phainon smiled back, blue eyes sparkling. “See you next Thursday, Mr. Future CEO.”

“Hey, I own my own business, remember?” Mydei said as he started walking around to the driver’s side. “Technically, I already *am* a CEO of my own little business!”

“Fine, Mr. Current CEO!” Phainon grinned. “Get home safe! Text me!”

“Will do. Bye, Phainon.”

Mydei was still smiling to himself as he got into his car and turned it on. With one last wave at Phainon and Snowy, he drove off, still smiling to himself all the while. For once, he didn’t mind the cold or the snow on the road, because now, they reminded him of a certain someone with hair as white as the snow and eyes as blue as the clear winter sky overhead. The cold could no longer touch him, because there was a warmth in his heart that Phainon had kindled. And Mydei was determined to keep that warmth burning, until it turned into a roaring fire.

He had no doubt that it wouldn’t be long at all until that happened.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> okay i got more ideas for this and it's nice having a low-stakes fic where phaidei can be yearning idiots without worrying about complex plots sooooo no idea how long this one will end up being but i'm just gonna go with the flow and see where it takes me! no complex plots or outlines allowed!! vibes and yearning only!!
>
> (but if you do want more complex ish plots, i started posting my 100k+ phaidei wip so check that out if you're interested!)
>
> also this has not been beta read and i proofread it but it's possible i just missed a bunch of typos so pls ignore those lol

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei was smiling to himself as he drove to work two days later, despite the insanely early hour. As a bakery, the breads and pastries had to begin baking early in the morning so they could be warm and fresh by the time the bakery opened at 5AM. Not many bakeries still did that, preferring instead to bake the goods the day before and heat them up before selling them, but Mydei was determined to be the best bakery and cafe around. Besides, he did it for the love of the craft. If that meant being at work at 2:30AM, then so be it. It was all worth it, in his eyes.

Cipher was already there by the time Mydei arrived at 2:30 on the dot. Stepping inside, the warmth of the kitchens and the smell of freshly baked bread washed over him, making Mydei's smile widen.

"Morning, Cipher," he said as he took off his coat and hat and hung them up. He reached for his favorite apron and tied it around his waist. "How are you today?"

"Oh, same old, same old," Cipher drawled, waving the thought aside. "Buuuuuut…how about *you,* hmm? What's gotten you so smiley this early? Surely not spending time with lil ol' me?"

Mydei snorted. Cipher was one of the few who could read him like a book. Of course she'd spot his smile from a mile away.

"Well, my weekend was quite eventful," Mydei said as he joined her in the kitchen, hands clean and ready to bake.

"Oh??" Cipher grinned. "Do share."

Mydei snorted again and tossed a handful of flour onto the counter. "Well…"

He told her about the snowstorm, about Snowy and the vet and finally about Phainon. Cipher shrieked and threw flour at him when Mydei said that he drove Phainon home.

“Look at you! And they say chivalry is dead!” Cipher grinned. “What’d you do next? He invite you inside for a drink to warm you up before you went home?” She wiggled her eyebrows at him.

Mydei blushed at the thought. “Er, no, but we went back to the vet the next day and I paid for Snowy’s vet expenses. Then I drove him home and…yeah, we have plans for dinner in a few days now.”

“Oh my god, you’re practically married already!” Cipher said. “Wait ’til Princess Homebody hears, ’cause she’s gonna be ecstatic!”

“Probably because she knows him,” Mydei said. “Small world.”

“Wait, she does?”

“Yeah? Don’t you, too?”

“Lionboy, you didn’t actually tell me your little lover’s name. I just know that the dog is named Snowy.”

“Oh. My bad. It’s Phainon.”

Cipher nearly dropped the full tray of cinnamon rolls she was holding. “*Phainon?* From Aedes Elysiae, loser Phainon? *That* Phainon?!”

“Loser?” Mydei frowned. “He’s not—”

“Oh, you don’t know him well yet, but he is. Don’t let that sleeper build fool you, dude is a loser.”

“Sleeper build?”

“I’ve known him for years,” Cipher explained. “He’s like the annoying younger brother I never wanted. He’s a dork. He only really got somewhat attractive in the last few years because Aglaea started mentoring him. I guess he was always secretly buff, though, since he grew up on a farm.”

Mydei blinked, heart stuttering at the idea that Phainon—dromas-pants-wearing Phainon, with his big, puppy-dog eyes and pathetic puppy energy—was secretly buff as hell. Could he throw Mydei around like a bale of hay then—?

He blinked again and mentally slapped himself. Not the time.

“I mean, he wasn’t like effortlessly flirty and cool when I met him,” Mydei said, continuing to knead and roll out dough. “Quite the opposite. He bawled a lot and then practically told me his whole life’s story in one single breath. Kind of impressive, actually.”

Cipher rolled her eyes. “He’s endearing, I guess, but don’t get your hopes up for some suave smooth-talker. Boy will fumble anything ’cause he’s clumsy enough. Just be prepared for your date to be awkward as hell.”

That just made Mydei smile. “That’s okay. I can be awkward too.”

“True. Zagreus knows your autistic ass can be so painfully awkward sometimes. Alright, I take it back, match made in heaven.”

Mydei snorted.

“Happy for you, though,” Cipher added with a smirk. “If you need any embarrassing stories of him, hit me up. And don’t be afraid to share once you see him do something embarrassing. Can’t leave a girl out of the loop, now, can you?”

Mydei let out a quiet huff of laughter. “Don’t worry, I’ll be sure to keep you and Castorice updated.”

“Oh good! Oooh, just a few more hours, and then I’ll get to see her reaction in real time!” Cipher laughed as she put another tray in the oven, happily humming to herself.

Mydei snorted and filled another tray, then pulled a finished tray of cinnamon rolls out of the oven to be frosted. The white icing reminded him of snow, and as a result, his mind went to a certain snowy-haired someone. Mydei blushed even more to himself. How embarrassing. He barely knew the man and here he was thinking and blushing about him at work. Ridiculous.

Little did Mydei know, at the same time in his own apartment, Phainon was also thinking and blushing about a certain someone. Even more so, because Phainon had found Mydei’s personal social media account. And he *might* have scrolled through the whole page and looked at every photo and read every caption instead of going to bed.

He couldn’t help it! Mydei was just too gorgeous! Phainon held onto the memory of him, but over the past few days, it was already getting fuzzy. Phainon couldn’t wait until Thursday to see Mydei’s face again. So instead of asking Mydei for a selfie in their chat or something, Phainon did what any other normal person would do and stalked him on social media.

First he found the bakery’s official account, which Phainon scrolled through with a growling stomach and a craving for a good cup of coffee, because Kephale above, all of those pastries and lattes looked *delicious* and Phainon hadn’t eaten much for dinner anyways. But a few posts had Mydei in them, some where he was a blurry, mysterious figure in the background just going about his daily business, and *some* where it was a closeup of Mydei himself holding out a pastry with a small, proud smile. Phainon *might* have stared at those pictures a bit too long, mostly because Mydei wore a form-fitting short-sleeve shirt under his apron, so his muscular, tattooed arms were on display for all to see. And gods above, did Phainon want to see.

So did everyone else in the comments—so many people openly thirsting over Mydei…it made Phainon seethe with jealousy, only for his heart to sink a moment later, because how the hell could someone like *him* get someone like Mydei?

It was a question he had been asking himself repeatedly over the past few days. There was no way Phainon wasn't going to fuck this up.

Those thoughts only intensified when Phainon found Mydei's personal account, which wasn't difficult to find since he followed the bakery's account *and* had it public. If Phainon thought those bakery photos were bad, then the tasteful, elegant, and beautiful photos on his personal account were even worse. Here was Mydei standing in front of a library in glasses—GLASSES!—and a knit scarf over a brown sweater, with photos of book recs and aesthetic shots of the history library also in the post. Here was Mydei on a rooftop bar, dressed in all black, hair tucked behind one ear to show off his sparkly, expensive, dangly earring as he sipped on some fancy cocktail. Here was Mydei laughing as he pet some stranger's dog while holding an ice cream cone in the other hand. Who the hell took these?! And could they please take some photos for Phainon as well?

It was like scrolling through the account of some K-Pop idol. Meanwhile, Phainon was sitting in his dark 1-bed apartment, wearing chimera pajamas, face bare, and sporting a bit of an acne breakout. There were empty chip packets on his bed. He felt like a slob, a complete nobody compared to Mydei.

Why the hell had Mydei helped him? Had been so kind to him? Why the hell had Mydei *chosen* him? When Phainon had been wearing dromas-patterned pants of all things! Phainon had bawled right in front of him! Ugly sobs and snot and everything! And yet somehow Phainon still got Mydei's number, a ride home, *and* a date?!

Maybe Mydei was messing with him, trying to toy with Phainon's heart before breaking it…

No. No, no, no. Mydei wasn't like that. And—Phainon checked the time—Phainon should really just go the fuck to bed. Snowy was already fast asleep in his own bed on the floor, so Phainon should get some rest, too. Besides, he had work and then class in the morning.

After a few pitiful hours of sleep, during which Phainon tossed and turned and dreamed of Mydei, Phainon dragged himself out of bed. Before work, he made sure to feed Snowy, give him his medicine, and take him outside. Phainon wished that he could stay home and watch over him, or even take Snowy with him, but he had already called out the past few days, and he really didn't want to test Aglaea's patience. He'd just have to rush home in between work and class to check on Snowy and take him out, forfeiting any time to buy or eat lunch and probably resulting in him arriving late to class. But it was worth it. Snowy was worth it.

Though…if things worked out with Mydei, maybe Phainon could ask him to swing by and take Snowy out for him?

No, no, no. Mydei had already done too much for Phainon and Snowy. Phainon had no right to ask more of him. He was lucky Mydei had refused payment in the first place, since Phainon sure as hell couldn't afford it.

With a sigh, Phainon hugged Snowy goodbye and headed out. The snow was already all half-melted, the roads perfectly clear. Phainon stared out the window of the bus, wishing for another snowstorm. He *loved* the snow, just like Snowy. But hopefully nothing traumatic

would happen on the next snowstorm. Hopefully the two of them could just stay safe and warm inside, watching the snow fall…

With Mydei?

Phainon sighed.

Aglaea was already there when Phainon arrived to work, frowning as she stood in front of a mannequin. She turned her head as Phainon walked in.

Phainon gave her a bright smile. “Morning, Aglaea!”

“Phainon,” she greeted. “How are you? How is Snowy?”

“I’m good, and he’s good. Just been sleeping a lot.” Phainon dumped his stuff at his usual spot at the crafting table. He nearly groaned at the sight of the pile of fabric waiting to be cut, the rack of clothes waiting to be hemmed. Sometimes Phainon really questioned why he even chose fashion as a discipline in the first place. Sure, he liked designing and making clothes—especially custom pieces for his family and friends as well as detailed cosplays for himself—but when he compared himself to other people in the industry, he couldn’t help thinking, *Come on, really? YOU?*

And yet somehow he had lucked out by meeting Aglaea, who ran her own shop and was one of the most sought-after designers and tailors in Okhema. Out of everyone, Aglaea had chosen *him* to be her assistant, her mentee. To this day, Phainon still had no idea why, but he wasn’t about to throw this all away by letting his anxiety get the best of him.

(He absolutely had tried already, but Cyrene more or less threatened to beat the shit out of him if he did, and that was enough to snap him out of it, because his gentle sister had never so much as hurt a fly)

(But from her tone, she had been 100% serious with her threat)

So here Phainon was, getting money, experience, *and* connections as he went to school on the side. This was something other students could only dream of.

And, despite the hard work, Phainon did enjoy it. He liked creating things with his hands. Liked the calluses and muscles and dexterity he built up. Just like how Mydei probably had several burns and muscles of his own from being a baker.

Phainon’s face and heart warmed at the thought of Mydei and his likely-callused hands…

“Well, quite a lot has built up in the past few days, as people have put in orders for winter wear and the like, but I don’t expect you to finish it all today,” Aglaea was saying.

Phainon snapped out of his thoughts. “Are you sure? I can come back after class to work some more.” That mountain of orders truly was daunting. Phainon would have to work extra to make up for it. His back was already groaning in protest.

But Aglaea was shaking her head. “Don’t overwork yourself, child. They’re not nearly as pressing. You should be taking care of yourself and Snowy. Besides, don’t you have finals coming up soon?”

Phainon groaned. “Don’t remind me.”

Aglaea smiled. “You will do well, don’t worry. And after that, just one more semester to go.”

During which Phainon would have to create a whole collection and try to make his way as a fashion designer. The mere thought made him sick to his stomach with nerves. He wasn’t ready to face the real world, with its lack of structure and guidance. Of course, he had faced it before in between his undergrad and now fashion school, but that was a dark and turbulent time that he’d rather not think about.

That time wouldn’t happen again. He had grown up. He was in a better place, mentally, financially, and socially. He had connections. He had Aglaea. He’d be okay.

Besides, that was months away. Phainon didn’t have to lose sleep over it. He had plenty of other things to lose sleep over.

Like Snowy.

And Mydei.

Phainon almost let out a dreamy sigh as he pulled the pin of fabric towards him. As he laid out the fabric and smoothed the pattern out over the top of it, he thought about Mydei and their future date and how Phainon was *not* going to mess this up.

Still…

“Aglaea,” he said.

“Hmm?” Aglaea tilted her head slightly but didn’t look away from where she was pinning something in place on the mannequin.

“Do you, um, have any advice about what to wear on a first date?”

Aglaea paused, then glanced at him. “Phainon, you’re a fashion student—surely you can come up with some ideas on how to dress yourself properly?”

Ha, that was funny.

Phainon grinned. “Well, in theory. But you know me, Aglaea.” He sighed. “Basically, this guy has already seen me in my dromas PJs, so I’d like to give him the impression that I *am* somewhat capable of dressing myself when need be.”

“Already saw you in *those*?” Aglaea teased. “*And* he still agreed to a date?”

“I know, I can barely believe it either!”

“He doesn’t happen to be blind, does he?”

“Hey!”

Aglaea chuckled. “Teasing. Clearly he isn’t, since he agreed to a date. Did you use those puppy eyes on him?”

“Er—sorta.” Phainon blushed. “Honestly, he’s already seen me ugly sob while wearing those dromas pants, but somehow I still got his number *and* a date, so either he’s got a few screws loose, or I must have done something right. Right?”

“Mm, what’s this mystery date like?”

Phainon sighed again. “Gorgeous. And kind. So kind. And rich. He, um, he’s actually the one who saved Snowy and brought him to the vet. *And* he helped me pay for vet expenses. I’m so in his debt right now, it’s not even funny. So dinner is on me, but I also have to figure out where to take a guy like him. I can’t afford a nice restaurant, but I can’t exactly take him to a diner, now, can I?”

“Oh my,” Aglaea said. “Sounds like you have found *quite* the catch.”

“I know!” Phainon groaned. “How the hell am I supposed to keep a guy like that? I’m gonna mess it up, I just know it. And no amount of cute dogs are going to keep him.”

“Oh, don’t give in so easily. You have plenty of charms yourself.” Aglaea paused and thought to herself. “Stick to blues, whites, and greys. No black, because that will be too harsh and should be reserved for a more formal date. Choose pieces that accentuate your shoulders, waist, and legs. You have a lovely figure, Phainon—make sure to bring attention to it. Do *not* hide it under those oversized hoodies and jackets you’re so fond of. Save those for later, when you’ve gotten to know one another and don’t need to try so hard.”

Phainon blinked, considering. “I do have a long, grey coat that’s tapered at the waist…maybe I should build my outfit around that.”

“Mm, yes, that one has a subtle striped pattern, doesn’t it?” Aglaea nodded in approval. “That’s plenty formal enough. Focus on other pieces that are a bit more casual so you can strike the balance between the two.”

Phainon was nodding as well as he went through his closet in his head. “I think I have a better idea now. Thank you, Aglaea.”

“Feeling a bit more confident?”

“I think so!”

“Good.” Aglaea turned back to her work. “And don’t stress about the dromas pants. Some people have a way of ending up together regardless. My husband was wearing a giant dromas onesie when I first met him, and here we are, ten years later, still married somehow.”

“Hold on—*what*?!”

*

Mydei arrived home just after noon, when Castorice showed up to relieve him and Cipher of their duties. Cipher wasted no time at all telling her all about Mydei's future date with none other than Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, and yet all Castorice could take away from Cipher's long, dramatic retelling was, "Snowy got hit by a car?!"

It was only after Mydei reassured her several times that Snowy was okay and recovering that Castorice said, "Oh, well, Phainon is very sweet and caring and often notices small things that no one else does. I think the two of you together would be very cute, so I hope everything works out!"

Mydei smiled, touched, while Cipher groaned and threw her head back in the background.

"Why are you two such hopeless romantics?" Cipher complained. "Ugh, fine, I hope your little date goes well. I expect a *full* update the day after, though, understand?"

"Please," Mydei said as he grabbed his coat, "I'll update the group chat the moment it ends."

With a smile on his face, he drove home, thoughts almost entirely preoccupied with Phainon and their upcoming date. Where would Phainon take him? What would Phainon wear? What should *Mydei* wear? Was Snowy doing alright?

Why ask himself these questions when he could just text Phainon and ask him instead?

So the moment he got home, as he slipped off his boots in the entryway, he texted Phainon.

Mydei:

How's Snowy doing?

He kept his phone unlocked and reached up to pull off his hat. The three dots showed up shortly after, making Mydei smile as he ran his fingers through his hair.

Phainon:

he's good! he's just been sleeping. he really likes his pain meds bc i give him a treat with it

how are u???

Mydei:

Glad to hear it.

I'm doing well. Just got home from work.

You?

Phainon:

im good! :) just let snowy out and now im omw to class! might get verbally flayed alive today tho

pray for me ;-;

Mydei:

?

Why verbally flayed…?

Phainon:

im gonna be like 30 mins late lolol

my prof hates tardiness

but i had a good reason okay!!!

Mydei:

Exactly, you had to take care of your dog.

Let me have a word with your professor. I'm sure I can clear things up…

Phainon:

O_O

Mydei:

?

Phainon:

thats

hot

Mydei snorted.

Phainon:

i mean!!

uhhhh sorry autocorrect

thats not!

not needed lol

thank u tho :3

Mydei:

Lol.

Excited for Thursday? I can say I’m really looking forward to it :)

Phainon:

!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

sorry keyboard malfunction

im excited too!!!

also

whats ur fav food?

Mydei:

Hmm, that's tough…I'm torn between waigu steak and gold-flaked truffles…

Which sounds better?

Phainon:

gold flaked truffles?!

i mean

both sound good :)

Mydei:

I'm kidding. Don't worry, I'm not expecting anything fancy. Honestly, I like burgers and pasta a lot. Not seafood though.

Phainon:

oh! cool cool cool

a steakhouse would work then right??

Mydei:

Perfect :)

Phainon:

:D

yay!!

ugh i should probs go to class now

text u later! <3

the heart is from snowy btw

Mydei:

Oh I’m sure

<3

Phainon:

fjdfxnzjndl

Mydei:

Keyboard malfunction. Lol.

Smiling, Mydei tucked his phone into his pocket and went into the kitchen to make a cup of tea.

*

Phainon:

hey mydei

how many books would u say youve read?

Mydei:

Like this year? This month? Or like my whole life?

Phainon:

oh jeez uh

like month i guess??

but now im curious abt life……

Mydei:

In my life? Too many to count. Especially considering how much I read as a child. Constantly had a new book in my hand.

This month, though, I have read four.

Phainon:

!!!!!

thats crazy!!

Mydei:

I enjoy reading. It's one of my only hobbies other than going to the gym and drawing.

Phainon:

not baking tho??

and u draw too???

Mydei:

I bake enough at work that I don't often bake on my own anymore. I still do for special occasions or if I randomly feel like it, though. And yes, I do draw. I learned how to animate last year, so I'd like to make a full short film one day.

Phainon:

waowwwwwww youre so cool!!! :O

do you have like an art account or anything???

Mydei:

…

I do…

Phainon:

oooooh can i see??? do u take commissions????

Mydei:

I'll show you in person sometime.

I don't often show people my art or animations.

Sorry, that part takes a bit more for me to share.

Phainon:

nono i totally get it!!!

thats me with any of my designs lol

on one hand im v excited to show my work but on the other i hate getting critiqued

we have to give & receive critiques at school all the time and i hate ittttt

i always wanna curl up and die lol

Mydei:

Well, whenever you want to show me a design of yours, I can show you some of my art.
Deal?

Phainon:

deal!!!

i might need your opinion on my final project whenever i finsih designing it

while i do hate critiques, sometimes its easier if i show it to someone i trust first and then brace myself for my class's critiques, u know?

Mydei:

I get that.

In my experience, I haven't really trusted anyone with my art.

Well, no one I know personally. At least when I post online, I don't care about people's opinions as much.

Phainon:

but strangers online can be so mean!!!

Mydei:

True. I've gotten good at ignoring them, though. Plus online has a block button.

Can't really do that in real life.

Phainon:

well u can but its generally frowned upon and gets u life in prison lmao

Mydei:

Lmao.

A little drastic, wouldn't you say?

Phainon:

depends on the critique??

Mydei:

Fair.

How was class? Home now with Snowy?

Phainon:

i survived!! skin still intact!! only got docked points. but should still pass the class.

and yep! snowy and i are in for the evening!

<photo attached>

he likes to act like a weighted blanket when i lie down on my bed

kinda hard now when the cone smacks me in the face tho

Mydei:

Haha,

Very cute :)

I assume you took the cone off after taking that picture?

Phainon:

<photo attached>

yup. after the bloody nose tho

blood + white dog

not a good combo

Mydei:

So…Snowy also got a bath? :)

Phainon:

Luckily I didn't bleed too much on him!!

So a sponge bath worked

Why are u still up tho?? Don't bakers ahve to wake up at the ass crack of dawn??

Mydei:

Oh I was about to go to bed. Lost track of time reading, and then you texted :) But I'll still get about 6hrs of sleep, so I'll be fine.

<photo attached>

Phainon:

fhjadsflkjhfdafahfkasdjlfh

holy shit

how r u so perfect???

u look like a model and ur just sititng in bed with a book

like how

meanwhile im here w my facemask and cat ear headband and a bruised nose and a slightly pink dog

Mydei:

And dromas pjs??

Phainon:

nah tonight its just regular black sweatpants that ive had since high school……

complete w white dog hair!!

Mydei:

Awww

Still cute.

Also, skincare is very important.

I like doing sheet masks too. And hair masks.

Phainon:

oooooh I havent tried hair masks…

my hair is weird. thin but dense?

ha like me!

badum tsh

Mydei:

xD

Hahaha

Phainon:

:D

but yeah my hair and skin are super sensitive

Mydei:

Also like you…?

Phainon:

hey now i cried ONCE

Mydei:

More like bawled.

Sobbed.

Weeped.

Definitely more than just cried.

Phainon:

my dog was at the vet!! afrer being hit by a car!!

worst first impression ever ;-;

Mydei:

Still got a number and a date out of it though.

Anyways, I have some extra hair masks if you want to try any.

Phainon:

fkbhjfjfjkakg

sorry glitched

but yeah!! lets take ibuprofen and do skin care together!!!

Mydei:

Not sure about the ibuprofen but sure :) It’s a date.

Phainon:

oh its a meme afdjhdfhf

but already scored a second date?!?!

how is any of this working?!

seriosuly ive never scored so much so quickly in my life ;-;

Mydei:

I find that hard to believe.

Phainon:

nah fr im a total mess when it comes to relationships

but i try! thats better than nothing right??

except for this scenario where ive somehow landed TWO dates witout even trying??

i mean i AM trying but not as MUCH

wait

omg

none of this is coming out right ;-;

Mydei:

Lol

Phainon:

i mean that somehow talking to you feels effortless and like i dont have to try as hard as i do with other people

i can just be myself

u know??

??

mydei??

ah shit

i totally just blew it, didnt i?

im sorry ;-;

we dont have to do the second date now, its okay!! totally get it if you dont even want to do the first one either

ill just…let u go for the night :) sleep well!!

*

Mydei:

Ah fuck.

I am so sorry.

I fell asleep.

At the worst possible time.

Phainon:

oh

Mydei:

??? Why are you still up???

Phainon:

er

couldn't sleep?

Mydei:

Shit, did I keep you up?

Phainon:

nonono my sleep schedule is wack anyways !!!

i usually stay up this late dw

did u sleep well tho??

Mydei:

I did…but now I regret it.

Phainon:

oh no! need ibuprofen???

i always get headaches if i sleep too much or sleep too little

or u know if i just like USE my head ahaha

which is why i dont! xD ahahahah get it?

…

i get headaches a lot ;-;

Mydei:

Oh, I feel fine physically, don't worry. But thank you.

No, I regret sleeping because I fell asleep in the middle of texting you. And you were probably up all night overthinking my lack of a response.

And most likely need ibuprofen yourself, now.

Phainon:

wha?? me?? overthink?? nahhhhhhhh

also how tf are you so good at reading me wtf

did u stalk my social media???

wait dont answer that

pls dont go looking for my account

wait now that sounds like i have something to hide

uhhhhh nvm do what you want i guess ahaha???

im gonna go slam my head against a wall now

Mydei:

Case and point lol.

Also, I think I understand why you have headaches now.

Do you have any allergies?

Phainon:

???

just to cats and thinking i guess lol

and to talking to hot guys apparently

why…????

Mydei:

No reason.

Phainon:

uh oh

do YOU have any allergies??

Mydei:

Not that I know of.

Phainon:

gah not fair!! now u know my many weaknesses but i dont know any of yours!!!

Mydei:

???

Are you deathly allergic to cats, thinking, and talking to hot men…?

Phainon:

nope not answering!!!

Mydei:

CAN one be deathly allergic to those things…?

Phainon:

lalallalalalalalala cant hear uuuuuuuuu

Mydei:

Hah

Go to sleep Phainon :)

And drink water with your ibuprofen.

Phainon:

ah okay

it was nice texting u tho

have a good day at work!!

Mydei:

Thank you.

Sleep well <3

The heart is for Snowy.

Phainon:

<3

he sends it back :)

*

"Cipher," Mydei said that morning during their usual prep work, "do you…know where Phainon works?"

Cipher wheeled around from where she stood at the ovens to narrow her eyes at him. "Why…?"

"Just…want to send him something." Mydei held her gaze, refusing to blush. His ears began to burn regardless.

She arched an eyebrow, staring him down for a few moments more before sighing dramatically and saying, "I *suppose* I do. Whatcha gonna give me in turn, though, hmm?"

Mydei crossed his arms. "Free dinner?"

"Eh, you did that last time. Can't blame a girl for getting bored." Cipher tilted her head to one side, smirking. If she had a tail, it would be swishing like a playful cat's right now.

"An extra day off with full pay?"

Cipher's eyes widened. "Do I get to choose the specific day?"

"It has to be sometime this schedule."

"Aw. But fine. Deal." She stuck out her hand. Mydei took it, the impact of their palms causing a puff of flour to rise. They shook.

"Whatcha gonna send him, hmm?" Cipher asked as Mydei washed his hands and retrieved a dark red box with a bow. "Two rolls and an eclair arranged to look like a dick?"

Mydei gave her a look. "I just want to send a little care package. And maybe some coffee. Not sure what kind he likes, though."

“You haven’t even gone on your date yet and you’re already sending gifts. Loser behavior. What about playing hard to get and being chased, huh? Like how you do with literally anyone else? What’s Loser Boy got that’s making you act all whipped?” Cipher gasped and then leaned forward, lowering her voice conspiratorially. “It’s gotta be the size of his dick, right?”

“How would I know that?” Mydei retorted as he started packing the box. “It’s irrelevant, anyways. I’m just doing this to be nice. Something tells me that he doesn’t take care of himself as well as he should.”

“Boo-hoo, he’s a grown-ass man.”

Mydei gave her a look. “As if you wouldn’t do the same if Castorice was going through a tough time?”

Cipher bristled like a cat, face flushing. “That’s—that’s different! I’ve known her for years, not three days.”

“And yet you’ve never made a move.”

“Yeah, ’cause I have dignity and don’t spread my legs the moment she bats her eyelashes at me.” Cipher huffed and crossed her arms.

“Hmm, not how I remember it.” Mydei smirked, then held out the box. “Wanna try being romantic for once?”

“Pfft, romance and I are not compatible. I’m much more interested in body talk.” Cipher rolled her eyes. “Whatever. Go chase after this loser. See if I care.”

“Thank you for your support. Now, do you think he’d like figs?”

“Could you date a man who didn’t?”

“Good point. I’ll include them and he’ll have no choice but to like them.”

Cipher grinned. “Attaboy.”

*

Phainon yawned into his hand as he stumbled into work, eyes still bleary, head aching. He seriously didn’t get any sleep, and he had no one to blame but himself. Of *course* Mydei had fallen asleep—he had to be up early and had only still been awake because of dumb luck! Why did Phainon have to overthink everything?!

Maybe he should take up journaling like Hyacine always told him to. As if that would help, seeing his unhinged thoughts on a page for all to see instead of safely inside his head for only

him to know.

“Good morning, Phainon,” Aglaea said, only to pause as she gave him a once-over. “Rough night?”

“Rough life,” Phainon joked with a crooked grin. He waved the thought aside. “Nah, just stayed up too late playing video games. You know how it is. Hey, maybe I could become a streamer if my fashion career doesn’t work out!”

“Hmm. As a man of many talents, surely you could find a much more prestigious career, couldn’t you?”

“Always believing in me.” Phainon smiled.

“Someone has to. But also, if your career doesn’t pan out, then it makes me look quite inept at being a mentor, doesn’t it? Not preparing my own mentee for success?” Aglaea *tsk*ed. “My reputation would take a nosedive.”

“Well, when you put it that way…” If there was one thing Phainon hated, it was letting people down. “I can just be a streamer in my free time. Side hustle!”

Aglaea rolled her eyes and turned away. “I suppose you’ll just be the most fashionably-dressed streamer there is.”

As Aglaea walked away, Phainon dumped his stuff at the crafting table, then paused when the smell of fresh coffee and baked goods reached his nose. He sniffed, stomach growling, before his eyes fell on a lovely, dark red box with a pink ribbon around it.

“Ooooh, Aglaea, did you pick up breakfast on the way in?” Phainon couldn’t believe his luck.

“Mm, no, that actually came for you. Special delivery.” Aglaea wasn’t even facing him, yet Phainon could hear the smile in her voice.

“Huh? Special delivery?”

Before Phainon could ask from whom, he spotted a small sticker on the box. *The Pink Pomegranate.*

Mydei sent this?

Wait, was *that* why he was asking about allergies?

Phainon carefully undid the bow and opened the box. The aroma was even more delicious without the cardboard barrier. It wafted out and hit him in the face, making him nearly sway on his feet. His stomach growled even louder.

Inside were several different kinds of pastries, all fresh and beautifully arranged. Phainon snapped a photo without hesitation. Would it be weird to save as his wallpaper? Along with the selfie of Mydei in bed, book resting on his chest and reading glasses on his nose, which

Phainon certainly did not gape at for hours upon hours last night? Yeah, probably…well, at the very least, he could post the photo of the pastries on his story online. Maybe tag the bakery in it so Mydei saw it…

Wait, that would mean Mydei would find Phainon's account—

Phainon shook his head to clear it. It was too early for such overthinking.

There wasn't any note, but there didn't need to be one. The box and pastries and coffee were a message of their own.

Phainon swallowed a lump in his throat as his heart pounded and swelled with warmth. Was it possible to already be in love this early? Was he insane? But also, how could he *not* be? He nearly sighed wistfully.

"Hey, Aglaea," Phainon called. "Want a pastry?"

*

Phainon:

have i ever told you that ur the best??

too good for this world??

def too good for me??

Mydei:

:)

I'm assuming then that you liked the pastries and coffee?

Phainon:

yes!!! how'd you even know where to send it??

gasp!!! stalker mydei confirmed?? :O

Mydei:

Of course not.

I just had Cipher stalk you instead.

:)

Phainon:

:O !!!!

that actually makes a lot more sense lol

sometimes i forget we have mutual friends and yet somehow have never met before this

Mydei:

I also wasn't quite sure what coffee you'd like or if you'd even like coffee at all, so I just sent a cup of one of our best sellers. Honey oat milk latte.

Phainon:

ITS AMAZING OMG

i don't think i can ever get any other coffee now

need to inject this stuff in my VEINS

also im gonna need like 500 more of those fig pastries like dfakjdfdjhghdfas

lowkey had a religious experience when eating them

aglaea was hardcore judging but eh i have no shame clearly

did you bake these yourself too??

Mydei:

Yep, everything in there was freshly baked this morning by me and Cipher.

I made the drink as well.

Phainon:

how r u single?! how has someone not snatched u up yet??

is it too early to propose??

wait dont answer that ;-;

for legal purposes that was a joke ahahaha

Mydei:

Lol.

I'm glad you liked it. :)

I hope you wore a good coat and hat and gloves today. It's quite cold out.

Phainon:

yeah its so cold!!! brrrrr!! almost froze when i took snowy out today!!

but the coffee and the gift warmed me right up ;))

i think i heard another storm is coming in ;-;

Mydei:

So soon?

Ah, I just checked the forecast. We're supposed to get several inches this Thursday…

Phainon:

several inches, huh??? ;))

Mydei:

?

Was that a dirty joke?

Phainon:

hmm? nope idk what ur talkin abt

;)

Mydei:

Lol

Well, I hate to say this, but if the storm is too bad, we might need to postpone our date…

Phainon:

what???? nooooooooooo!!!! :’((

Mydei:

Postpone. Not cancel.

Phainon:

i know but its already felt like an eternity since i saw you ;-;

even picked out my outfit and everything

thats ok tho. i can wait. ur worth it!!!!

wait for me mydei!!!!!

Mydei:

Well, we could do a call or something that night instead…

Phainon:

ooooooooooh

OR u could come to mine and we could cook together and get snowed in together :))

Mydei:

Tempting. But perhaps we should save that for another date.

Before you overthink, I'm not rejecting you. I just figured we should take it somewhat slow, just in case. A date like that sounds lovely, but not until we've gotten to know each other a bit better.

Even though it already feels like I've known you forever, Mydei thought, but he didn't allow himself to type that. That would be way too much, way too soon. That wasn't Mydei's style, anyways.

Phainon:

started to overthink ngl lol but u already know me too well dfkjsdfjhfdh

stopped the spiral before it got too wild!!

ay that should be my slogan…….kinda has a nice ring to it….

Mydei:

Just for my sanity, let's plan on doing a video call for Thursday. And then we can plan the steakhouse for our second date. That way, neither of us will put ourselves or others in danger by being out in that snowstorm, if it's going to be as bad as they're predicting.

Phainon:

sounds good to me! :D

ill make sure to wear my dromas pjs just for u <3

the pretty date outfit may have to wait for its moment, but the reliable ol dromas pants shall rise from the ashes once again!!!!

Mydei:

Lol

I look forward to it :)

<3

Chapter End Notes

hehe posting this on the clock at work?? more likely than you think!!

End Notes

also not-so-fun fact: this fic is inspired by me witnessing a dog unfortunately getting hit by a car on the highway in a snowstorm...i was not as heroic as mydei and couldn't safely stop to help the dog, but we did call animal control and they told us that they had people out looking for the dog already. i hope they found him and that he's home safe and sound. anyways i cried the whole drive home. but hey sometimes life events give you some really good fic ideas ;-;

i might?? write more to this?? i do have some ideas but no promises since motivation is fleeting nowadays but let's just say the possibility is not zero...

anyways, thank you for reading!!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!